

“THE NEED FOR RESEARCH,” REVISITED

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Abstract: As part of a special issue aimed at reflecting on the one-hundred-year anniversary of the establishment of the communication discipline and what the earliest issues of its flagship journal, *The Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, could tell us about issues still confronting intercollegiate debate now, this essay examines James A. Winans’ (1915) “The Need for Research.” It argues that, whereas for Winans the exigence was enhancing academic prestige for speech teachers among their fellow, more established university colleagues, at stake now is the intercollegiate debate community’s academic prestige in communication departments and the broader university. Whereas in 1915, many of the leaders of the emerging discipline were also leaders in the debate and forensics community, pressures of “sportification” have driven debate teachers and coaches away from devoting substantial energies toward practices of research and publication. By offering an ecosystem metaphor, this essay argues that an arrangement of “non-relation” between debate and academics puts the former in peril and limits the potential growth of the latter; that a parasitic relationship (most notably, of debate seeking money and other resources) likely leads to the end of their support by such departments; and that only a symbiotic approach, where both parties contribute to each other in ways that both see, understand, and respect offers a viable future for debate and a future filled with greater opportunities for communication departments and universities as a whole.

“There is a tendency . . . to consider that debating exists for its own sake . . . debating is but a device. It is valuable, extremely valuable, but in no sense an end in itself, in no sense permanent or indispensable to civilization, to a liberal education.”

-William Hawley Davis (1915, pp. 112-113)

“I hold that by the scholarship which is the product of research the standing of our work in the academic world will be improved. It will make us orthodox. Research is the standard way into the sheepfold.”

-James A. Winans (1915b, p. 17)

Introduction

Communication’s centennial anniversary, celebrated by the National Communication Association in 2014, offered an opportune time and occasion (*kairos*) to reflect on the discipline. Many important histories of the discipline were told as part of this process, especially in reflecting on the conversations contained in the early issues of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, the discipline’s flagship journal, which we know today as the *Quarterly Journal of Speech*. Some offered reflections on the role, past, present, and future, of debate in relation to the discipline (Hicks & Greene, 2015; Jamieson, 2015; and T. Parry-Giles & S. J. Parry-Giles, 2015). Other scholars reflected on the importance of this history, without specifically focusing on debate (Wilson, 2015), while still others reflected on the state of research and scholarship in the discipline in general, back then and 100 years later (Darsey, 2015; Medhurst, 2015). Scholars with connections to the debate community (as current or former competitors, judges, or coaches, and/or as researchers investigating debate-related issues) have been offered this opportunity to engage in a (re)appraisal of the discipline, debate, and debate’s status in and relationship to the discipline. Indeed, this special issue represents one opportunity to weigh in on some of these important questions.¹

This is not the first time that reflection on debate has occurred. Most notably, debate coaches and

scholars seized the opportunity to raise such questions at the 1974 Sedalia Conference (McBath, 1975). More recently, at a debate conference in 2009 at Wake Forest University, the community reflected again on these perennial questions (Louden, 2009). Apart from these specially convened, rare historical moments of meta-reflection about debate, ongoing channels for debate scholarship exist. This journal, whether under its current title, *Contemporary Argumentation & Debate* or under its previous title, *CEDA Yearbook*, has been published since 1980, while *Speaker and Gavel*, the journal of the national forensic honor society Delta Sigma Rho-Tau Kappa Alpha, is currently on its 52nd volume, and according to its website, its history can be traced back to the beginning of the Twentieth Century. Moreover, debate maintains an institutional presence at the National Communication Association. The home organization of this journal, the Cross Examination Debate Association (CEDA), has a set of panel slots at each annual convention, with traditional academic paper and panel presentations (including a recognition of top papers) as well as performance panels and business meetings. Therefore, the debate community has had both ceremonial, summit-like moments to engage in self-reflection, while maintaining ongoing, institutional venues for these conversations to occur.

What, then, does this particular moment offer us? For many of us who identify as scholars interested in textual analysis of rhetoric, argument, and debate, this historical juncture offers a welcome opportunity to look back 100 years ago, to discover which questions were deemed provocative and timely in the first issues of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*. Even in the first issue, questions of pedagogy, research, the newly created discipline, competitive speech and debate, and others all arose, not in isolation (as they seem to

now), but in a way indicating that, in 1915, such *topoi* were interconnected and mutually informing. Looking back, then, offers an opportunity to reflect on where we were, where we are now, and where we may be headed (descriptively) and, perhaps more importantly and aspirationally, where we want to be headed (normatively). Though these initial issues and the early history of debate and the discipline offer numerous rich points of entry, I focus on a question that engages debate as part of a larger picture.

These early articles (and more broadly, the early issues and volumes) explored many issues related directly to debate (most especially regarding judging—who is fit to judge, for instance—and regarding ongoing academic and public conversations about “switch sides” debating). However, given the substantial attention paid to those issues in extant scholarship, I opt instead for a theme present in these early articles, but less frequently engaged in contemporary debate scholarship. I focus on the first issue of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* (1915), in which Kay (1915) praised the new journal as an opportunity to develop an “*esprit de corps*” enabling the discipline’s members to have a shared space for developing individual and communal professional identity.

In particular, I analyze James Winans’ call for research by the newly formed discipline of public speaking teachers, “The Need for Research” (1915b), an essay which led to substantial disagreement and debate in the same journal (Hunt, 1915; Winans, 1915a; The Research Committee, 1915a; The Research Committee, 1915b). Though the Winans’ passage cited to open my essay aims at the discipline (of, to be precise at the time, “public speaking”) and its members’ responsibilities, I argue that the inside-outside dynamic has changed. His words apply to the

contemporary debate community, which is now the entity seeking standing, not in academia writ large, but in the communication discipline specifically.² Through the use of an ecosystem metaphor, I suggest that the stakes of this question are high, and what may be at risk is large not only for competitive debate, but for the communication discipline as well.³

Debate and Scholarship: Symbiosis, Parasitism, and other (Non-)Relations

Articles in the first issue of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* addressed, more and less directly, issues still at the forefront of debate theory and practice in the 21st Century. For instance, Lane (1915) explored how actively involved faculty/coaches should be in preparing students for competition. Shurter (1915) examined possible relationships between high school and college speech and debate contests/programs, exploring the telos of *citizenship* as their guiding justification. The “Editorial” section (“A disconcerted editor and others,” 1915) probed the pros and cons of switch-sides debate—a topic also animating contemporary scholarship about debate (see Greene and Hicks, 2005). These examples all suggest a mode of scholarship that is not wholly insular and confined within the debate community. Lane’s essay examined how debate educators, who wear many hats including teacher, coach, and scholar, should balance such demands in a way that is both competitively fair and pedagogically justified. Shurter’s essay explored what happens when debate exceeds its own borders to encourage new communities to take part, thus (hopefully) (re) shaping all of these communities, including debate’s own community, in the process, and how such calls for expansion should be advocated. And the “Editorial” piece (“A disconcerted editor and others,” 1915) responded to the public challenge, from sources like *The*

New Republic and former president Theodore Roosevelt, about whether debating both sides of a question can be defended, not just for tournament competition, but as a practice worthy of emulation in a broader democratic culture. In all three examples, the focus of inquiry was simultaneously about debate and beyond debate. Mitchell, et al. (2010) advocated this type of inquiry in demarcating scholarship that would qualify for their Debate Authors Writing Group (DAWG) approach:

To ensure that research projects retain ties with academic debate, but also speak to a wider readership beyond the forensics community, our working group developed a two-fold scope requirement...products must either 1) make academic debating a point of departure for analysis engaging issues of concern for those beyond the debate community, or alternatively 2) deploy an “outside-in” approach that uses analysis of academic debate as a destination point for scholarship that begins with treatment of topics relevant to wider society. (pp. 3-4)

This “scope requirement” is a vital precondition for any relationship to exist between debate and communication departments (and academia more broadly). Scholarship failing this test suggests, in its insularity, either a lack of relationship to its surrounding academic culture, or a parasitic relationship that sees no need to generate contributions for that wider culture despite the institutional support (especially including funding) that institutions provide for debate. Woods, et al. (2006), as members of that DAWG experiment, put this scope requirement to the test in writing about digital dilemmas germane but not exclusive to members of the debate community. Following the ecosystem metaphor, debate scholarship, as it continues to (re-) grow, should strive for a balance between debate as the

point of departure and the “outside-in” model. Heavy reliance on the latter suggests taking ideas from our colleagues to apply to our context rather than exporting ideas that might enhance the scholarship of our colleagues.

This two-way street, one of mutually informing work that engages debate practice, pedagogy, and scholarship, is neither a myth of an idealized past nor an impossible burden for would-be debate scholars. Instead, this approach is representative of a broader trend in the history of debate and scholarship:

Argumentation studies in American speech communication sprang from modest roots...The linkage between debate and argumentation in general has been pursued in both directions. Not only has debate drawn from an understanding of argumentation; it also has contributed to it...debate is still too often seen as something of an academic stepchild rather than as an evolving intellectual tradition with far broader implications...many of the leading American scholars of argumentation were introduced to the subject through contest debate and found it an important influence on their subsequent work...the case of academic debate illustrates very well a recurrent pattern in the speech communication discipline. Rather than being driven by grand theories tested through application, the discipline has tended to construct theories as needed to explain or to solve the problems encountered in practice...debate is both a pedagogy for and a continuing test of Dewey's belief that public policy issues can be researched and debated by a “public” composed of nonexperts. (van Eemeren, Grootendorst, & Henkemans, 1996, pp. 193-196)

In the next section, I examine various iterations of the historical narrative to illustrate the varying relationships between debate, on the one hand, and the scholarly community (especially those studying communication) on the other.

Histories, Metaphors, and Possibilities

Atchison and Panetta, in their contribution to the *Sage Handbook of Rhetorical Studies* (2009), detailed in great depth the early history of debate. They too looked to those first years of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking* to see what was being discussed regarding debate, as both inspiration and comparison for the challenges facing the debate community in the Twenty-First Century. They noted, “In an era of tightened budgets, directors are increasingly pressured to defend the benefits of intercollegiate debate” (2009, p. 325). Atchison and Panetta identified several communities involved with such a defense. On the one-hand, there is the relatively insulated college debate community, many of whom favor the inwardly-focused, competitively-driven “debate as innovation” approach (2009, p. 325). Such an approach may be difficult to defend, due to practices and arguments that appear odd to the outside world (speed reading and arguments that seem far-fetched to lay audiences, for instance). Another approach, “debate as activism” (2009, p. 326), places greater value on (debate community and broader) social change. But there seems to be a significant omission in terms of communities, without whose support these “tightened budgets” may very well be at risk.

In an age when even teaching-oriented universities and liberal arts colleges are increasingly requiring faculty to publish academic scholarship as a part of their job duties, debate cannot continuously attempt to

exempt itself without some substantial risks. Indeed, in Atchison and Panetta’s (2009) framework, those who are seen as research scholars seem necessarily separate from those involved in debate coaching and pedagogy:

[E]very institution has unique scholars who... could be of benefit to the debate community. The input of scholars who study argument, communication, race, gender, sexuality, economics, and the various other academic interests could provide valuable advice to the debate community... Attempting to create an insulated community that has all the answers ignores the potential to create very powerful allies within academic institutions that could help the debate community. (p. 328)

This vision implies an autonomous, inwardly focused team, seeking academic connections elsewhere, rather than itself (and its coaches) being a source of academic scholarship. It suggests a parasitic “what can the rest of the university do for me” view rather than an attempt at addressing the symbiotic challenge: How can we engage in reciprocal relations where we both draw from other university resources but also make meaningful, academic connections and contributions in the university and beyond? Perhaps instead of fearing the fallout from off-the-wall arguments or videotaped performances, we might instead be concerned with how to defend debate programs and budgets to those without first-hand experiences of the value of debate. This exigence intensifies as faculty members and administrators with debate experience retire. Trophies and positive public relations stories about competitive successes can be achieved at a cheaper cost elsewhere in the university, and public debate and debate across the curriculum initiatives may lead some to question why the tournament space is also necessary, particularly given its cost.

When considering budgets, as well as the high premium and competition for faculty and staff lines of employment, how does debate justify itself? Publication is in many ways the gold standard of the modern university (and no longer only of the research-intensive subset). If a debate program cannot at least minimally justify its work in this area, it may be forced to become a self-sustaining organization apart from any formal academic unit (dependent, for instance, on sufficient alumni donations for creating a protected program endowment). Everyone suffers in that situation, as opportunities for meaningful cross-pollination and symbiosis become obscured or disappear entirely. Consider, then, two contrasting accounts of the intercollegiate debate tournament: First, "Tournaments provide unique sites for innovation and experimentation that might provide a forum for participants, coaches, and other communities to discuss better the goals and objectives of intercollegiate debate" (Atchison & Panetta, 2009, p. 325). Here, the tournament aims at better understanding debate, and innovation and experimentation occur in terms of competitive practice, rather than, for instance, in terms of argument schemes or rhetorical strategies. Alternately, consider a second assessment of the tournament space: "The rise of tournament competition as an organizing *telos* augured debate's ascetic turn, characterized by heightened specialization, intensifying insularity, and fetishization of technique. . . . the activity took on the patina of an exotic sporting event" (Goodnight & Mitchell, 1998, p. 95). What is the alternative, in this latter account? Providing the exemplar of David Zarefsky, they note:

Zarefsky's *oeuvre* challenges us to invent modes of academic debate that celebrate and reinforce the tournament structure, while also building out from that structure to overcome its insularity. The

most promising efforts would blend competition, scholarship, pedagogy and public engagement, with the various dimensions of forensic practice synergistically interlocking to form a virtuous circle. (Goodnight & Mitchell, 2008, p. 92)

Though Atchison and Panetta's (2009) suggestions for transcending the hyper-competitive and activist extremes do inform competition, pedagogy, and public engagement, they appear to omit "scholarship." Given the focus for this special issue on the past as guide for present and future, consider this extended narrative, which in its rich detail invites us to see the promise of symbiosis and synergy that arise from closely interrelated ties between debate and scholarship, allowing both to flourish:

Debate has long preserved a place for practical reason and argumentation in American universities. In public debate events, then later at intercollegiate tournaments, students, teachers, and audience members would gather to redeem the promise of an activity with ancient roots and durable salience. In United States colleges and universities, debate societies are among the oldest programs on campus. These programs have attracted students interested in testing the force of the better argument, and they have engaged in a vibrant "participatory culture" for well over a century. Scholarly analysis of the practical and theoretical challenges involved in the debating enterprise created a path for the study of argumentation that shaped the larger academic field of communication. Although the study of argumentation has gone global, debate continues to develop in relative obscurity, its participants absorbed by practice and its transitory conclusions evaporated into the internetworked society's digital ether. Yet debate remains a rich storehouse

of communicative action. Debate entails a unique form of contention that draws its rules into itself, enabling conversations that link theory to practice and prompt participants to reflect constantly about how their performances relate to evolving norms and conventions of argument. (Goodnight & Mitchell, 2008, p. 81)

Here the narrative is similar to that offered by Atchison and Panetta (2009). The primary difference comes in the role that academic scholarship plays (or should play) in the process. Though Atchison and Panetta (2009) listed many esteemed rhetorical critics of the past who were at one point involved in debate, such as Edwin Black, Celeste Condit, Douglas Ehninger, and Marie Nichols (p. 322), such elements of history, absent a push to make debate a site of rich scholarship once again, will tempt observers to frame the work of such luminaries as unique and incapable of being repeated, and thus as mere nostalgia.

Yet, there is much uncharted and valuable scholarly potential in competitive debate (including in its tournament setting) as a launching pad for study. When members of the debate and forensics community gather for weekends of competition across the country, innovative and noteworthy argumentative and communicative interactions and practices take place that could be situated in theoretical contexts in scholarly writings. But, often, scholars and debate coaches never seize the opportunity to claim such interactions as legitimate scholarly endeavors. Thus, outside of the judges, coaches, competitors, tournament hosts, and perhaps loyal readers of forensics websites, Facebook pages, and other electronic forums (such as listservs and bulletin boards), the communicative encounters experienced in the tournament setting are never relayed to the academic community or the public

writ large. As Leeper argued, “What we do can have a tremendous impact on our students, our institutions and our communities. We belittle ourselves if we limit our thinking to the ‘game’ of debate” (1997, p. 407).

As we consider the future relationship, or lack thereof, between mainstream communication scholarship and competitive debate, we return to the metaphor of the ecosystem. Of the various possible relationships among organisms in an ecosystem, one is a mutually beneficial symbiotic relationship. Here, both organisms gain from the relationship. In the history of debate and the discipline of communication, there have been clear moments of mutual support and gain. As a contrast, when one organism benefits while the other is hurt, we have a parasitic relationship. Those not involved in debate may look at debate budgets and wonder what the return is on that massive investment. Finally, when two organisms do not seem to have any mutually impacting relationship, we might term it (though not a metaphorical term) nonrelational.

Many on both ends, departments and debate programs, seem to go their own way, unaware or uninterested in the other’s valuable labor. But, whatever normative entailments arise from such a possible nonrelation, the history of the last 100 years suggests that it would not be possible, at least in any straightforward way, to claim that the relationship between debate and the discipline of communication is truly one of nonrelation. It may feel that way at times, but when material stakes get high (travel budgets, faculty/staff lines, etc.), it becomes clear that there exists and will continue to exist some relation between these two parties, if both are to continue to exist. So, the true question becomes: Which ecosystem works best and what does it look like? When debate is at its most “sportified,” there exists little for the academic

department to see as a benefit from having a debate program, apart from trophies and press releases that might mention the department. Not only is there the monetary issue (described above), but it also begs the question- what are you adding to the department? Especially in terms of research and scholarship, if there is not a clear, positive answer to that question, the justification for housing the program may begin to crumble. Meanwhile, more senior, tenured faculty who may have debated and/or coached themselves retire. As that landscape changes, the assumed persuasiveness of a wholesale enthymeme, where the value of debate is presumed to be self-evident to and tacitly understood by all parties, becomes a dangerous bet on which to rest the future of debate programs.

Furthermore, the parasitic relationship, or even the one that suggests a basic nonrelation, risks a second chain of arguments that could do a disservice to both debate scholarship and academic debates. While 100 years ago debate was a prominent portion of the discipline, and while it has had many great moments since, that history-as-enthymeme for continuing to justify debate may not pass along unchallenged. Research scholars in many departments might argue that the early Twentieth Century scholarship, with its focus on pedagogy and in general lacking a highly theoretical framework, might be considered more primitive, an earlier evolutionary stage that is useful now primarily because it got us to the next step, not because we still need it. As Keith (2007) explains, “certainly, confusions, weak scholarship, and dead ends can be found, from which a cynic might conclude that we may safely not look back” (p. 346). Though Keith himself rejects such “cynical” conclusions, he points to a real sentiment regarding debate and debate scholarship. Indeed, such impressions feed what van Eemeren et al.

(1996) referred to as the perception at times of debate as “something of an academic stepchild rather than as an evolving intellectual tradition with far broader implications” (as previously quoted). For those voices, even recovery efforts like this special issue, or like the debate-related portions of the *Quarterly Journal of Speech*’s special centennial issue, represent history and nostalgia, not an argument for centering current and future research programs in the areas of debate.

Part of the problem, then, is in talking and acting like debate is an independent, autonomous thing, apart from any connections (such as to departments/universities); that is, as if what mattered were the individual organism, rather than the larger ecosystem it inhabited. Not only does that seem to be an illusion (witness the funding arguments), but even if it were possible, it seems disadvantageous. There is something positive about mutual dependence, in nature and in argumentation, as it generates a sense of vulnerability, one that is shared, creating a feeling that we are “in it together,” and thus all feel a responsibility of upholding one’s part of the bargain. Thus, even if non-relation were an ecosystem possibility (which it cannot be, and thus why it does not fall in with the rest of the metaphorical cluster), it would breed a sense of atomization away from communication and academia more broadly, with troubling consequences. As Billings (2001) argued:

One of the basic justifications for forensic research postulates that...the forensic environment can be used to study real-life communication. Proponents...argue that findings we learn in competitive forensics can be applied to the outside world—a forensic laboratory...Yet, over the past few decades, the concept of the forensic laboratory seems to have disintegrated, in...a

disturbing trend...to become more isolated from the mainstream speech communication curriculum. (pp. 17-18)

Fortunately, parasitism and a misleading “nonrelation” are not our only options and possibilities.

Navigating Our Way Back to Symbiosis

At each key inflection point in the history of debate as an academic activity, the challenges faced have appeared significant, but have ultimately been managed (whether in deferring, re-casting, or fixing—even temporarily—the problem). Similarly, we must consider how to adapt in light of our own context and challenges. Fortunately, the past offers us guides and inspiration.

Much of the scholarship that has turned inward to self-reflexively probe the problems facing debate has offered recommendations and solutions (Leeper, 1997; Loudon, 2009; McBath, 1975; Mitchell, et al., 2009; Mitchell, et al., 2010). I would argue that the debate community might more systematically mine those resources as already established mechanisms for addressing the deficit of debate scholarship. In any case, rather than reiterate those suggestions, I offer here some initial steps that offer points of entry for those in the debate community seeking opportunities to (re-)connect with research and scholarship and thus revitalize ties with colleagues in communication departments and across campuses.

Debate has been, like the academic discipline of communication, tied from its roots to strong pedagogical means and ends.⁴ One challenge concerns how pedagogical insights offered from debate theory and practice might speak to broader scholarly conversations about pedagogy. Though it often tends

more toward scientific than critical/humanistic approaches, the popular, interdisciplinary research trajectory known as the Scholarship on Teaching and Learning (SoTL) would offer space to not only shuttle insights from debate into scholarship, but also insights from communication and rhetoric for an interdisciplinary, similarly pedagogically-oriented audience. For instance, debate as an activity has always, by necessity and for strategic gain, been at the forefront of technological change. In the past, that has meant that debate could serve as a pivotal tool for translation in the academy about the opportunities created by shifts to features like electronic academic databases (Leeper, 1997).

Though specific technological challenges have morphed, the need for debate to adapt accordingly has remained constant, leading to ongoing conversations about digital debate practices (Woods, et al., 2006). At a time when digital information overload has generated demand for tactics that rein in economies of attention (Lanham, 2007), debate can again serve as a voice in the university community for how to meaningfully make use of this bewildering information overflow. The time seems ripe to join the conversation. One particularly provocative and influential interlocutor in this dialogue, José Antonio Bowen (2012), has written a book that has already received much uptake by educators, provocatively titled *Teaching Naked: How Moving Technology out of Your College Classroom Will Improve Student Learning*. Paradoxically, his argument is not about reducing the use of technology in pedagogy, but if anything increasing its use by prioritizing when and how it can be used to the greatest advantage. By creating a technology-rich pedagogical ecosystem that extends far beyond the physical classroom, it allows educators to foreground what is still relevant and worth

the “price tag” of higher education: in-class interaction between faculty and students. As Bowen (2014) noted:

While most of us remember a not-so-distant past of knowledge scarcity...The world is now knowledge-rich, and students today can use their phones to access more information than is contained in any college library. College is like an app for the mind; filtering, analyzing, and synthesizing content is increasing in value...Our real goal is to improve how students integrate new information...Most students are able to use technology in ways they find useful or entertaining, but they are markedly less proficient at using technology to access or assess information...we need to think very carefully about how our students process and integrate what they access. (paras. 2-9)

Such calls, along with widespread adoption of digital “information literacy” assessment and enhancement, populate many conversations in higher education. Debate could be a vital voice in this discussion. Long before the current information overload economy, debate had already created situations of overabundance of information (number of arguments in a speech or debate, number of argument briefs, quotations, and “cards” to serve as evidence for claims, number of disciplinary domains from which arguments might emerge). Therefore, those debaters best able to, in the words of Bowen, filter, analyze, synthesize, integrate, access, assess, process, and integrate information, in a short period of time, also have tended to be those individuals most successful as debaters, judges, and coaches. We could offer lessons learned by having taught and cultivated such skills and approaches, not just in the last few years with the digital information, but over decades of purposefully creating this exact kind of pedagogical situation.

The preceding suggestions indicate that a focus on translating our pedagogy into publication-worthy research and scholarship might enhance prestige of debate teacher-coach-scholars among their communication colleagues and also across campus, in interdisciplinary conversations that are trying to figure out how to articulate the value of a university education in this dramatically transformed information economy. Such efforts could then, as previously indicated, lead to publication opportunities in interdisciplinary settings. But if part of the purpose, as indicated earlier in this essay, is to increase standing with communication studies colleagues, we face the challenge of writing and publishing in venues that are likely to be seen and given due credit by those individuals. We continue to maintain journals whose focus is on debate (or, more broadly, forensics), including this journal and *Speaker and Gavel*. There are journals whose specialty is argumentation, and who used to publish debate scholarship more frequently, including *Argumentation and Advocacy*.⁵ Certainly, debate scholars can continue to publish here and in *Speaker and Gavel*. Ideally, as such scholarship becomes read and cited more frequently, it leads traffic back to these journals as a whole. Debate scholars can also publish in *Argumentation and Advocacy*, which appears to maintain an interest in debate scholarship.⁶

Unlike in the days of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, articles about debate no longer show up on a regular basis in the flagship journal, now the *Quarterly Journal of Speech*. But if the argument presented above holds, that manuscripts that seek neither the “point of departure” nor the “destination point” approaches—in which debate interfaces in one way or another with broader academic and scholarly lines of inquiry—then part of the challenge may be to more intentionally

draw such connections. The question becomes then: Will the wider scholarly (communication and beyond) have interest in our discussions of debate? I would argue that, with properly constructed interfacing, there is reason to hope that it might. For instance, Mitchell (2006) was not only published in the *Quarterly Journal of Speech* but was awarded the 2007 Top Article Award for the Political Communication Division of NCA. Similarly, Woods (2010) won the 2011 Outstanding Dissertation Award from the American Society for the History of Rhetoric (ASHR). Such examples suggest that, if adapted and framed appropriately, scholarship that is both *about* debate and simultaneously *beyond* debate could find a home in many of the discipline's top journals. And, each time another article makes it into those journals not traditionally defined as debate-focused journals, it creates space for those that might come after it.

Many other mid-level suggestions might be added here. For instance, prospective debate directors might leverage their initial negotiations, regarding contract terms, to argue for the inclusion of the time and space to conduct research that would then end up strengthening their teaching and coaching. In discussing fiscal considerations relating to debate lines, Leeper (1997) noted:

[H]iring a coach with a masters degree is cheaper than paying for a tenured faculty member....instructor lines...are desirable because the class load is generally heavier—giving the university more bang for its buck. The pedagogical reasons for hiring a director with a doctorate must be made equivalent to the cost of paying for that director. (p. 406)

Or, I might add, the research productivity reasons for

hiring must be made equivalent, such that coaches willing to take on the risks of the publishing model would also inherit the opportunities, whether or not their lines were formally designated as tenure-track. Another way to strengthen the research possibilities for debate coaches would be to more formally structure, into communication graduate programs, coursework opportunities meant to develop debate professionals, not just for administrative, coaching, or teaching enhancement, but into the area of scholarship about debate and how to take part in those conversations. Some examples of this have occurred, but primarily as directed studies rather than catalog offerings.⁷ We could also offer awards to that rich reservoir of former debaters/judges/coaches with highly impressive track records of publication, whether or not their scholarly program is specific to debate. By recognizing and welcoming them back into the community, we might create opportunities for possible article collaborations between them and current members of the debate community,⁸ or they might serve as research mentors, were we to identify up and coming debate scholars.

Finally, in this essay and in the treatment of debate and forensics more broadly, some of the substantial shortcomings and missed opportunities may create a bit of a false impression. There are programs around the country that are making efforts at combatting sportification. For some, that includes a set of public debates, on campus or in the community. For others, this means hosting international tours, such as those from Great Britain and Japan⁹ and/or partnering with various components of the iDebate Rwanda program. And these are just a few. Not all of these programs represent a move toward scholarship and research, but they all point in the direction of supporting debate as more than *merely/exclusively* tournament

competition. We should nurture such ventures, while also considering how such work could be developed into scholarly contributions of value to those across the communication discipline and beyond. And, given the consistent and sustained support that this journal and *Speaker and Gavel* provide for scholarship and discussions about debate, these journals would be ideally suited for bringing back a feature of those initial issues of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*: a forum piece that includes shorter pieces and active back and forth conversation about debate, in each issue. In that forum, there could be a section devoted to spotlighting programs engaging in innovative approaches and practices on their campuses and beyond. And, following the popularity of the buzzword in academia and the corporate sphere, such features could potentially offer “best practices” for possible emulation by other programs, which could become sites for scholarly reflection and writing.

The preceding recommendations offer a buffet approach rather than one that requires that many/all the steps be taken in order to be effective. Such suggestions should be read in tandem with previous calls, offering a rich repository of options for those in the debate community who are genuinely interested in enhancing debate’s scholarly profile but, like their peers, are limited by finite time and seemingly infinite professional and personal responsibilities. One final suggestion, perhaps the most long-term of them all, nevertheless holds potential as a way in which debate professionals alone might be able to lead a movement that would end up benefitting many of their colleagues in departments of communication.

A Modest Thought Experiment

The historical relationship between rhetoric and

debate is in meaningful ways isomorphic, as indicated by many of the early articles in the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*. For instance, the criticisms of the Sophists of ancient Greece, that they were solely focused on winning and technique, rather than on notions like the Good, the True, or the Just, have been applied consistently to critique debate as well. Additionally, Roosevelt’s criticisms of switch-sides debate seem driven by a larger concern over debate’s value and goals. Plato’s distrust of the Sophists may very well find its counterpart in Roosevelt’s distrust of intercollegiate debate. Therefore, while not all debate teacher-coach-scholars are also rhetoricians by trade, there is a consistent and strong relationship between the two fields. Though the fortunes of debate and rhetoric have sometimes followed similar trajectories, each has had unique factors helping and/or hurting them. One such factor is the way in which both arts were received by Harvard and other prominent Ivy League institutions. Jay Heinrichs, in an essay for *Harvard Magazine*, entitled “How Harvard Destroyed Rhetoric,” documented rhetoric’s rise and fall at Harvard, other Ivy Leagues, and academia/society writ large. Chronicling Harvard’s gradual expulsion of rhetoric, he argued:

In the midst of an increasingly oracular society, the College requires that its students study expository writing...but doesn’t offer a single course in which oratorical theory and practice are taught together. As the ancients understood, the two are inseparable. And as Harvard goes, so goes the nation. Harvard’s example helped destroy classical rhetoric. Harvard’s example could still help revive it in elite colleges nationwide...Without an education in argument, they are missing out on one of the greatest intellectual skills. Society suffers from the

lack of educated citizens who accept the uses of debate, who want to be persuaded, and who have the sophistication to avoid being manipulated. This last may be the academy's greatest lack. Skepticism is the vaccine that keeps our national rhetoric from turning malignant. Without it, we're a nation of dupes. (Heinrichs, 1995, p. 42)

This passage sounds like a justification for competitive debate that could easily have been written in 2015, 1955, or 1915. Elsewhere, Heinrichs (1995) claimed, "This is the story of how rhetoric was swallowed up by Harvard, and how Harvard might atone for its sin by giving back a skill that is sorely needed by Americans today" (p. 37). Heinrichs pointed to other institutions such as Dartmouth as additional evidence of the hostility toward/disregard of rhetoric at the Ivy League institutions in the United States. But what does this have to do with debate and its role? Why not leave this fight to the rhetoricians? Adopting a symbiotic approach rather than a parasitic or non-relational approach may offer some answers.

Rhetoricians have been making efforts to persuade Ivy League colleges and universities, throughout the Twentieth and Twenty-First Centuries, to bring back rhetoric, as a "rhetorical renaissance" (Medhurst, 1998, p. 309) has occurred elsewhere in the academic world, including the development of prominent scholarly institutions such as the Project on the Rhetoric of Inquiry (POROI) at the University of Iowa, and the prominence of talk about the "rhetorical turn" across a wide range of disciplinary boundaries (Al-Musawi, 2009; Hariman & Beer, 1996; Nelson, 1990; Rutten & Soetaert, 2017; Sills & Jensen, 1992; Simons, 1990). Similarly, rhetoric is back in the mainstream in many parts of the academic landscape in the United States. As Herrick (2005) noted, "Many colleges and

universities are again offering courses in rhetoric after having banished the term from their curricula for years, and dozens of books are published every year with *rhetoric* in their titles" (p. 1). Such efforts have been unsuccessful at Ivy League institutions, as classes, faculty lines, and departments with a significant focus on rhetoric do not exist there. However, though Ivy League schools view rhetoric skeptically, debate may enjoy greater favor by such universities.

However, if debate scholars view rhetoric skeptically, they may enjoy a different status. Winans (1915b) asked, "Will research in public speaking be permitted in the universities?" Part of his response read, "Professor Winter informs me that the outlook is hopeful at Harvard" (p. 22). Based on the assessment put forth by Heinrichs, this outlook was not likely in reference to support of the study and teaching of rhetoric there. And yet we might be justified in asking what might have been? For instance, both Harvard and Dartmouth have elite debate programs, and while there is not a corresponding communication department with which they can be linked, their successes seem to be valued by the universities writ large. Similarly, there are prestigious forensics programs (in such events as parliamentary debate) at a number of Ivy League institutions. We might then wonder how, if just at the time that the rhetorical renaissance was flourishing in the academy (and to a lesser degree, in society writ large), debate as a space worthy of research and academic publishing was retreating in favor of a competitive, insular model, what missed opportunity that might have represented. In other words, if Harvard (and its fellow institutions) are looking for evidence that debate and rhetoric are not "merely" pedagogical and/or extracurricular activities, but are instead valuable sites for high quality scholarship,

might debate not, even now, be a foot in the door for communication scholars seeking to justify rhetoric's and communication's legitimate place in the academic structure of these elite universities?

As previously mentioned, the currency of the contemporary university, apart from currency itself (in the form of grants, donations, tuition and fees, etc.), comes in the form of academic publications, demonstrated by the increasing expectation that, even at traditional "teaching colleges" or even liberal arts colleges, faculty should be publishing alongside their teaching and service responsibilities. But at the most prestigious research universities, publications are, beyond all else, *the* means of legitimation and success. If, then, debate as practice is celebrated by these universities and can demonstrate its full scholarly potential, might it be a pathway, a foothold on which communication and rhetoric can justify their return from a long exile? This is intended more as thought experiment than as program of action, but it may be suggestive. If we were to see ourselves as worthy and capable of running debate programs at Ivy League institutions that were fully integrated into the universities' academic matrices, and were rich in scholarly production, pedagogy, tournament travel, and public debate, think what the next 100 years could hold.

Indeed, this possibility may not merely be an aspirational hypothetical. During the 2009-2010 academic year, David Zarefsky, whose relationship with debate has been upheld as a model for advancing debate as a rich scholarly endeavor (Goodnight & Mitchell, 2008), held a Visiting Professorship in the English Department at Harvard. While this step alone is not definitive proof that rapprochement is possible, it suggests that debate could indeed be a significant

part of the mechanism to spur thawing and mutual engagement. Thus, rhetoric, a discipline whose roots can be traced in many ways to an Ivy League institution, Cornell University, and the Cornell School of Rhetoric (Benson, 2003), whose luminaries included James Winans, Everett Lee Hunt, and Herbert Wichelns, might have a way of coming back home, in part with the advocacy from and ties to academic debate.

Conclusion

Many others have suggested ways by which debate community members might reclaim and revitalize our relationship to scholarship. For instance, Mitchell et al. (2010) discussed the "blind spot" of the Sedalia Conference, relating to the lack of attention to *how* debate coaches-teachers-scholars, given the multiplicity of demands on their time, might carry out the vision put forth there. They put forth the "Debate Authors Working Group" as a model corrective in the face of such demands and constraints. Elsewhere, note that the 2009 Wake Forest Debate Conference witnessed the birth of the online journal *Timely Interventions: A Transnational Journal of Public Policy Debate*. Though not intended as a traditional peer-reviewed outlet for debate teacher-coach-scholars, it nevertheless offered a model that was designed to build on work that had already been done in competitive debate contexts and to translate it into scholarship that was both peer-reviewed and meant to intervene in ongoing public policy debates (Mitchell, et al., 2009; Mitchell, et al., 2010). At this point, judging from the website's archives, there has been just *one* essay published by the journal, despite being formed in 2009.

In engaging this body of work, I have added some additional suggestions. It may not be completely useful, though, given the limited uptake of previous efforts,

to merely continue to generate new approaches that would make the entry barrier into research lower and the context more friendly and inviting. Instead, such recommendations may need to be coupled with some bitter-tasting medicine. Seen this way, the spirit of Winans, who was speaking to all public speaking teachers for whom research was of questionable value and necessity, comes across quite clearly to those who have, at some point or another, developed in their academic careers with ties to debate. He wrote:

We have lacked scholarship. We complain of prejudice and unjust discrimination, and we have grounds; but we had best face the truth. In the long run men (*sic*) pass for what they are. We have lacked scientific foundation for our special work. We have fought a great deal about our particular way of doing things. Some have stood for imitation, some for systems of rules, or other systems; and many have thrown all systems away and preached the one magic word, "Think," without much consideration of what thinking involves. It is a great word, but salvation lies in no word. We are split up into all sorts of schools of belief. To a certain extent that is desirable, but we fail to agree on the most fundamental matters. We have of course made spotty progress; but if we are to make rapid progress and deserve fully the recognition we demand, we must have the services of investigators; we must encourage young men (*sic*) to take up research in our field. I am talking to my own kind now. I have no great humility before teachers in other lines. Toward them we bristle with defiance. But that is just the trouble—we do bristle. We are not able yet to take ourselves for granted. We shall feel better and do better when we can. And this is where I connect the higher with the lower motive: we shall not only stand better but teach better, when we have more scholarship; when we have

the better understanding of fundamentals and training in the methods which test and determine truth. (1915b, pp. 17-18)

Winans' task was to speak to his "own kind": teachers of public speaking in a newly configured disciplinary matrix. The in-group/out-group anxiety particular to the reflections of Winans (1915b) here was how other scholars in the academy would treat speech teachers. One can imagine that, having just broken away from English, they would be a part of the audience who would judge. But, he also mentioned disciplines like medicine, economics, and engineering (1915b, p. 18), and indeed put forth all other approaches to knowledge in comparison: "Now, is there any reason, in this age when every other branch of human knowledge is being ruthlessly pulled to pieces and tested why our branch should be passed over?" (1915b, p. 18).

If we re-situate and listen to Winans' exhortations as being directed toward those in the debate community, we gain something that remains vitally important for debate on its own terms and in its larger contexts. While the specific, highly scientific model Winans suggested (1915b) may no longer reflect where the majority of debate teacher-coach-scholars are, the spirit of his challenge is one that remains as important to us in 2015 as it was 100 years ago. And combining the spirit of his own call with those who, at the time, seem most fiercely opposed, such as Everett Lee Hunt (1915), we have a vision that can be modulated based on type of scholarship (humanities, social scientific), type of institution (land grant, research, liberal arts), and type of researcher (undergraduate or graduate student, staff, faculty). In this way, debate might once again put itself in a position to match its capabilities, strengths, and opportunities with its historical situations.

The Morrill Acts of 1862 and 1890 acted as a powerful force in the growth of forensics in the United States (Bartanen & Littlefield, 2014). More recently, the Boyer Commission Report, *Reinventing Undergraduate Education* (1998), challenged research universities in particular to create a new model that puts a primary value on the development of communication skills as well as on undergraduate involvement in academic research. The framework for educational reform ushered forth by the Boyer Report offers just the kind of kairotic moment to put forth debate as a means of making undergraduates into actors rather than receptors, and as a means of linking their insights from competitive practice to those intellectual traditions regarding debate, argumentation, rhetoric, and communication, as cultivated by the discipline of communication studies.

The overlapping communities of debate, academia, and society would all stand to benefit from a more sustained engagement between debate and scholarship, leading to that hopeful eventuality Winans hoped for: "I look forward to a good time coming when our work will have the recognition we crave for it; and that will come as a matter of course when we have developed a body of established knowledge" (1915b, p. 23).

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Endnotes

1 Following Mitchell, et al. (2010, p. 2 [notes 1 and 2]), two preliminary remarks deserve mention. First, in the early history of the discipline, the umbrella term *forensics* united speech and debate events as part of a common whole. Accordingly, even in the first issues of the *Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*, a spectrum of forensics activities, and not just debate, were featured prominently. Such an approach is not especially common now, either in the organization of competitive programs or in the writing on these various events as a common, united entity. In this essay, I primarily refer to debate, rather than forensics, for two reasons: a) much of the specific academic literature I examine, historical and contemporary, explores debate in particular, and b) my own forensics experiences were in debate (in particular, policy debate), including competing in, judging, and coaching NDT-CEDA debate. Such experiences allow me to address potential shortcomings and opportunities in that community that might not be mirrored in other forensics communities. My analysis should not preclude similar histories and recommendations, whether about other debate types or about non-debate forensics activities. Indeed, subsequent work could act as a corrective to the blind spots that necessarily arise from any particular telling of history.

2 Such calls for reflecting on and enhancing academic status and legitimacy are not new, and have in particular been made previously by and toward the debate/forensics community. One recommendation adopted at the 1974 National Developmental Conference on Forensics (known popularly as “the Sedalia Conference”) reads, “All members of the forensics community should be acquainted with, and should feel a responsibility to contribute to, research and scholarship” (McBath, 1975, p. 37). This bold proclamation seems reminiscent, in content and tone, of Winans’ 1915 call, but seems to have been, in uptake and actualization, less successful as a clarion call to its respective community. Indeed, if the debate community continues to memorialize Sedalia as a landmark moment (such as the 2009 Wake Forest Conference framing itself as Sedalia’s third iteration), this call for research and scholarship should command

attention alongside and no less than other recommendations, simply because the latter might seem less threatening and/or difficult. Indeed, just as Winans promises the reward of heightened status among colleagues, Sedalia too framed scholarship as the key to status: “in the words of one conferee, ‘If forensics is to improve its status with colleagues and in other disciplines, it will be through heightened emphasis on research and scholarship’” (McBath, 1975, p. 34).

3 If this essay’s tone appears at times direct or even sharply challenging, such a framing comes with a two-fold purpose. First, it offers a mimicry of Winans (1915b), not merely in content but also in form and tone (Winans even frames his essay as a discussion and refutation of the most frequent objections he has previously encountered when “preaching the following doctrine” [p. 17]). Second, though my essay is not meant as polemic or diatribe, the sheer quantity of calls for more debate scholarship (most notably in high-profile settings like the 1974 Sedalia Conference) alongside suggestions of how that might occur (e.g., Mitchell, et al., 2010), has not been able to generate clear-cut, sustained change as a result, making it feel like the situation requires an exhortation of “last resort” (Windt, 1972). That being said, this essay also provides not just a repeated call toward the *telos* of more and better debate scholarship, but a discussion of additional means by which that goal might be realized.

4 What we now call communication was originally conceived of as “public speaking,” as in the original name of the flagship journal, *The Quarterly Journal of Public Speaking*.

5 Or, as it was formerly called, the *Journal of the American Forensics Association*, an organization devoted to forensics and debate.

6 However, venues such as *Argumentation and Advocacy* might respond that a lack of debate-related submissions, coupled with the “insular” debate scholarship problem described above, represent reasons why more work of this type is not currently being published there.

7 For instance, John Rief and I took part in a

directed study with Dr. Gordon R. Mitchell at the University of Pittsburgh in the Fall 2005 semester, which explored interactions and relationships between debate programs and larger academic institutions. As a result of this highly focused coursework, the three of us created the Schenley Park Debate Authors Working Group (DAWG) and invited a set of fellow Pitt graduate students with expertise in debate to join at the start of the following spring semester.

8 Regardless of whether such research collaborations are focused on debate-related scholarship, planting such partnerships encourages the growth of more publication-capable members of the debate community.

9 These international tours are coordinated by the National Communication Association's Committee on International Discussion and Debate (CIDD).

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